AI CONFERENCE 2026 | F1-THEMED TEAM COMPETITION

HACKATHON ROUND BRIEFING

THREE ROUNDS | TEAMS OF 4 | TOP 5 REACH THE FINAL BUILD RACE

AT A GLANCE: Three rounds. After Round 2, the top 5 teams advance. After Round 3, every team receives exactly 2 minutes to pitch what it has made.

1. Base instructions

Each team has exactly four students and stays together throughout the competition. Round 1 is individual; Round 2 and Round 3 are collaborative team stages.

Devices: Bring your own devices according to your team's needs, with a maximum of two devices per team.

Tools and preparation: Come prepared with the coding and AI tools needed for Round 3. Only free AI tools may be used; paid AI tools are not allowed. For example, use VS Code with an AI assistant available on a free plan. Internet access is permitted in Round 3 for tools and documentation.

AI-use rules: AI and AI-generated content/code are prohibited in Rounds 1 and 2. In Round 3, AI-assisted web coding is allowed using free AI tools only. Any failure to follow these rules results in team disqualification.

2. Hackathon overview

All participating teams begin together. The event runs through three rounds, followed by team pitches. Round-specific instructions and materials are issued at the start of each round; transitions are directed by Race Control.

Stage	Timing	What participants do
Opening briefing	Before Round 1	Hear the general rules and team instructions. Round-specific directions and materials are issued at the start of each stage.
Round 1: AI & Coding Qualifier	15 minutes exactly	Complete and submit an individual paper independently. No collaboration or AI.
Round 2: Team Challenge	30 minutes	The task, all required resources, and instructions are provided on event day. Work together and submit the required response. No AI.
Qualification results	After Round 2	Round 1 and Round 2 results are combined. The top 5 teams advance; all others are eliminated. Qualifying order sets the final starting grid.
Round 3: Final Build Race	90 minutes total	Use the first 20 minutes to plan and submit the plan to the lead/coordinator. Coding may begin only after submission; use free AI tools only.
Team pitches	Immediately after Round 3; exactly 2 minutes per team	Each team pitches what it has made. Every team gets exactly two minutes.
Final judging	After pitches	Judges assess the submitted work and the team pitch.

3. Detailed instructions by round

Round 1 — AI & Coding Qualifier | 15 minutes exactly

Each student receives a paper and completes it independently. It covers general AI concepts, coding logic, and problem-solving. No collaboration and no AI are allowed. Submit the paper as directed.

Round 2 — Team Challenge | 30 minutes

The task, all resources required for it, and the instructions will be provided on the day of the event. Work with your team to complete the task and submit the required response by the announced cutoff. AI is prohibited throughout this round.

Round 3 — Final Build Race | 90 minutes total

The top 5 teams build and test a working web application using the instructions issued at the start of the round. The first 20 minutes are the Safety Car planning phase. Outline the project structure, main screens or sections, core features, and user flow. Submit the initial plan to the lead or coordinator when the 20 minutes are up; coding may begin only after submission. Follow the submitted plan through to the finished project.

AI-assisted web coding is allowed during Round 3, but only free AI tools may be used; paid AI tools are prohibited. Coding or no-code tools and internet access for tools/documentation are permitted.

Optional DRS — halfway through the 90-minute Final Build Race: An optional bonus task is announced when the window opens. Teams may attempt it or continue with their planned build. No advance task details are provided.

Final submission: Submit by the hard deadline; the shared team folder locks at that time. Include (1) the working project as a file, code, or accessible link, (2) any output requested in the Round 3 instructions, and (3) a one-page Race Summary.

Team pitch: Immediately after Round 3, each team pitches what it has made. Every team gets exactly 2 minutes.

4. Judging & penalties

Qualification: Round 1 and Round 2 results are combined to rank teams after Round 2. The top 5 advance; all others are eliminated. Qualifying order sets the Final Build Race starting grid.

Final judging: The Round 3 project, required output, and each team's 2-minute pitch are scored using the 100-point rubric below. There is no separate live demo. No tie-break procedure is specified.

Rule	What to know
AI-use violation	Any failure to follow the round-by-round AI rules results in team disqualification.
Late or missed checkpoint / submission	Yellow Flag: 10% deduction from that round's score.
Pre-built code or plagiarism	Black Flag: disqualification if detected at scrutineering.

Late or missed checkpoints, including the initial plan deadline, are subject to the Yellow Flag penalty. Race Control instructions and deadlines apply throughout the event.

Judging rubric criteria

This 100-point rubric applies to the Final Build Race project, required output, and pitch. Round 1 and Round 2 results are combined for qualification after Round 2.

Criterion	What judges assess	Points
Alignment with the submitted plan	How closely the final project matches the team's 20-minute plan.	30
Functionality and completeness	Whether the project works reliably and includes the required components.	35
Usability and clarity	How easily users can understand and navigate the project.	20
Two-minute pitch	How clearly the team explains its work within exactly 2 minutes.	15
TOTAL	**Final Build Race score**	**100**